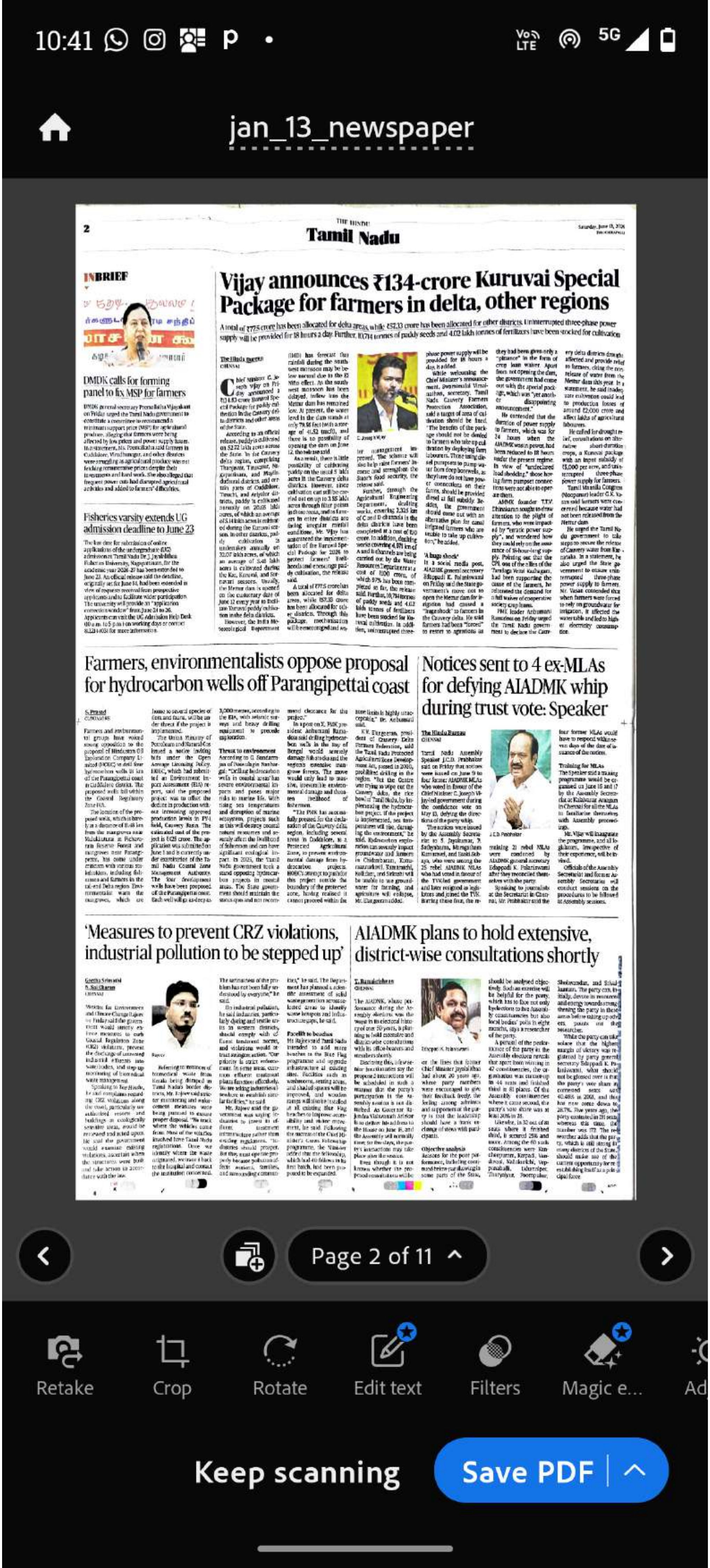

IN BRIEF

DMDK calls for forming panel to fix MSP for farmers

Fisheries varsity extends UG admission deadline to June 23

Vijay announces ₹134-crore Kuruvai Special Package for farmers in delta, other regions

A total of ₹77.5 crore has been allocated for delta areas, while ₹57.33 crore has been allocated for other districts. Uninterrupted three-phase power supply will be provided for 18 hours a day. Further, 10,714 tonnes of paddy seeds and 4.02 lakh tonnes of fertilizers have been stocked for cultivation

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

'A huge shock'

Farmers, environmentalists oppose proposal for hydrocarbon wells off Parangipettai coast

S. Prasad
CUDDALORE

Threat to environment

Notices sent to 4 ex-MLAs for defying AIADMK whip during trust vote: Speaker

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Training for MLAs

'Measures to prevent CRZ violations, industrial pollution to be stepped up'

Geetha Srimathi
R. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

Facelift to beaches

AIADMK plans to hold extensive, district-wise consultations shortly

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Objective analysis

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THE HINDU

City/Region

3

Delta farmers in a quandary on kuruvai cultivation

Water level in Mettur dam

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Tiruchi Junction to get six additional escalators by the end of this month

Railway Division takes innovative measure to check accidents at all the 139 non-interlocked level-crossing gates; division will be totally electrified when Pattukottai-Aranthangi-Karaikudi section traction work is completed in this financial year

Tiruchi Railway Division bags 8 efficiency shields

TIRUCHI TODAY

Blackout at Papanasam railway station for several hours leaves passengers exasperated

In-charge V-C takes charge at CUTN

KUMARAGURU
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Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay at the Kollur Mookambika Temple in Udupi district on Friday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

T.N. CM Vijay visits Kollur Mookambika Temple, offers sword

The Hindu Bureau
MANGALURU

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay visited the Kollur Mookambika Temple in Udupi district of Karnataka on Friday and offered a silver sword to the presiding deity.

This is his first visit to Karnataka since taking charge as the Tamil Nadu Chief Minister.

Sources said the sword weighed 1.6 kg. He offered a special puja at the temple in the afternoon.

Security tightened

The police had beefed up security at the temple in view of his visit. The temple wore a deserted look due to the security arrangements.

After visiting the temple, Mr. Vijay drove to the Mookambika guest house at Kollur.

Sources at the Mangaluru airport said the Chief Minister had driven the car himself while returning to the airport from Kollur.

He waved at his fans and boarded the special flight to Chennai at 6.30 p.m.

Earlier, Mr. Vijay arrived at the airport by a special flight from Delhi around 1 p.m. Minister for Health and Family Welfare U.T. Khader and officials of the Dakshina Kannada district administration welcomed him at the airport.

The officials presented him with two books at the airport. He left for Kollur via Udupi by road.

Black flag protest

Before Mr. Vijay could reach Udupi, a group of activists of the Karnataka Rakshana Vedike (Praveen Kumar Shetty faction) gathered at Udyavara on National Highway no. 66 in Udupi to show black flag to the Chief Minister.

The activists were opposing Tamil Nadu taking objection to the proposed Mekedatu irrigation project.

They were taken into preventive custody by the police.

No new cases of Nipah in Kozhikode; 3 hospitalised

Ten more added to the updated contact list, taking total number of contacts under surveillance to 87; health workers intensify surveillance measures; NCDC to extend support at the district level

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

A security guard installs a warning board outside a Nipah isolation ward at the Government Medical College Hospital, Kozhikode. PTI

No new cases of Nipah virus infection has been detected in Kozhikode district, Kerala Health Minister K. Muraleedharan said on Thursday.

However, three individuals currently under quarantine have been admitted to hospital for observation, and their samples have been sent for testing.

The patient undergoing treatment after testing positive for the virus has been administered the first dose of a monoclonal antibody therapy in accordance with Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) guidelines and on the recommendation of the medical Board.

The Minister said 10 more people had been added to the updated contact list, taking the total number of existing contacts under surveillance to 87 on Friday. Of them, four were categorised as highest-risk contacts, 16 as high-risk and 67 as low-risk contacts.

As part of the intensified field-level surveillance measures, health workers conducted a house-to-house survey in 286 households in ward 5 of the Ramanattukara municipality, where the Nipah case was reported. Twelve persons with fever were identified during the comprehensive survey completed on Friday. None of them exhibited symptoms associated with Nipah infection.

A meeting of the rapid response team was held in Ramanattukara to review the containment zone management plans and surveillance activities.

Health Department sources said a team of experts from the National Centre for Disease Control (NCDC) would soon come up with their scientific field report by assessing the situation and extend their support to the Health Department staff at the district level.

ED issues fresh summons to Pinarayi's daughter Veena in CMRL pay-off case

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has reportedly issued a fresh summons to Veena T., daughter of former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, asking her to appear at its Kochi office on June 17 in connection with the probe into the alleged pay-off case involving Exalogic Solutions Private Limited, Ms. Veena's now-defunct firm, and Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL).

She was supposed to appear before the ED for questioning on Friday. The fresh summons comes in the wake of her request to postpone her appearance citing health grounds. She is supposed to appear at 10 a.m. with relevant documents.

The ED had summoned Ms. Veena along with Sasidharan Kartha, chairman and managing director of CMRL, and senior company officials on June 9 as part of the probe. The others have been asked to appear on June 15.

The ED had on May 27 raided the residences of Mr. Vijayan as part of the probe into whether Ms. Veena's now-defunct firm had received sizeable monthly retainers from the CMRL, a public limited company, during the 2017-2021 period allegedly without rendering any tangible service. It has also been accused that Empower India Capital Investments Private Ltd., operated by Mr. Kartha, had extended loans worth ₹50 lakh to Exalogic despite it allegedly failing to make timely repayments.

During the course of the raids, the ED had frozen ₹18.26 crore.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select stations yesterday

Forecast for Saturday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Odisha and Kerala. Heat wave conditions likely at isolated places over Telangana, Vidarbha and Rajasthan. Hot and humid weather likely at isolated places over Maharashtra and Konkan & Goa.

Check drugs, narcotics trafficking, T.N. Minister tells officials

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUCHI

S. Ramesh, Minister for Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments (HR&CE), greeting the participants at the review meeting at Tiruchi Collectorate on Friday. M. MOORTHY

Minister for Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments S. Ramesh on Friday urged the officials of various departments to take steps to check the movement and use of banned drugs and narcotics in the district.

Chairing a review meeting with officials, Mr. Ramesh said the State government had committed to safeguard the people from drug abuse.

There was a need for enhanced vigil against illegal sale of drugs and banned tobacco items.

The officials concerned should take steps against those responsible for it.

He said importance should be given to creating necessary infrastructure such as drinking water supply, roads, bridges, sanitation facilities and so on. Attention should be paid to environment protection, solid waste management, and cleanliness. Government schemes should be implemented in a transparent manner and on time. Officials should utilise digital technology to offer various services to the people.

Later, the Minister said that he would review the progress of various schemes with the officials once in a month.

Deputy Speaker M. Rasisankar, Collector Pratik Tayal, Commissioner of Police N. Kamini, Corporation Commissioner Veer Pratap Singh, Additional Collector (Development) T. Swati, Superintendent of Police Dongare Pravin Umesh, and senior officials of various departments were present.

Naidu slams YSRCP for 'spewing venom' against NDA; hails Centre's support

A.D. Rangarajan
TIRUPATI

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister and Telugu Desam Party (TDP) national president Nara Chandrababu Naidu has flayed the YSR Congress Party (YSRCP), accusing it of systematically unleashing a negative campaign against the NDA regime in an apparent bid to portray the State in a poor light.

Addressing a public meeting on Friday organised at Dandedu to celebrate two years of the NDA rule in the State and 12 years of the NDA rule at the Centre, he lambasted the YSRCP for "spewing venom against the alliance regime and filling the people's mind with confusion and disbelief".

"We are focusing on taking the fruits of development to the people. But the YSRCP is working on a single-point agenda of spreading lies and unfounded charges among the public," Mr. Naidu said.

He alleged that the YSRCP's social media wing was trying hard to promote suspicion and hatred against the ruling dispensation by spreading misinformation.

Recalling the stand taken by the YSRCP ahead of the 2019 election, such as implementing total prohibition, recall of Contributory Pension Scheme (CPS), announcement of job calendar every year and support for Amaravati as the State's capital, Mr. Naidu wondered if it had fulfilled at least one of the above. "On the other hand, they are doing everything to bring disrepute to us, solely out of frustration," he charged.

Rebuilding Amaravati

"They divided the districts in an unscientific manner, we corrected it by forming Markapuram, Madanapalle and Polavaram. They had absurdly brought Land Titling Act. We initiated resurvey exercise to solve land disputes. They enacted the 'three capitals drama', but we are rebuilding Amaravati," Mr. Naidu said.

Identify inmates languishing in jails despite acquittal, HC tells T.N. govt.

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

Coming across a case where a person acquitted of all charges after his mental health condition was ascertained continues to languish in jail for the last 10 years, the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has directed the State government to conduct an inspection and ascertain whether similar such persons were languishing in jails across the State.

The court was hearing a petition filed by the man's brother from Ariyalur district.

The petitioner's brother suffered from paranoid schizophrenia and was accused of hacking their mother to death in 2006 following a quarrel with their parents.

Mahila Court in Ariyalur, on ascertaining the mental health status of the accused, came to a conclusion that he was suffering from chronic mental health condition and acquitted him of all charges.

While acquitting him, the trial court directed him to be detained in Tiruchi Central Prison till the State government decides to deliver the accused to any of his friends or relatives.

The grievance of the petitioner was that for the last 10 years, his brother continues to be inside Tiruchi Central Prison.

A Division Bench of Justices N. Anand Venkatesh and K.K. Ramakrishnan said this was one of the most unfortunate cases where an accused person after having been acquitted from all charges continues to languish in jail for the last ten years. This was the height of violation under Article 21 of the Constitution.

If really the person concerned was suffering from a chronic mental health condition, to ensure his protection and in the interest of society, he has to be placed in a Mental Health Institute and he can never be detained in a jail.

The court posted the matter for hearing to June 22.

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(A Joint Venture of Govt. of India & Govt. of Tamil Nadu)
(ISO 9001:2015 AND ISO 14001:2015 CERTIFIED)
Metro, Anna Salai, Nandanam, Chennai - 600 035.

E-Tender Notice

CMRL invites tender through CPP Portal (https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app) from eligible firms who fulfill the qualification criteria as mentioned in the tender document under Single Stage Two Cover (Technical & Financial) system for the work mentioned below:

Tender No. CMRL/CP/RTDR-72-CS/2026 "Project Management Consultancy Service for Property Development and Other Works".

(i) Bid Document available from: 16 June 2026

(ii) Deadline for Bid submission: 23 July 2026 up-to 15:00 Hrs.

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Chennai Metro Rail Limited

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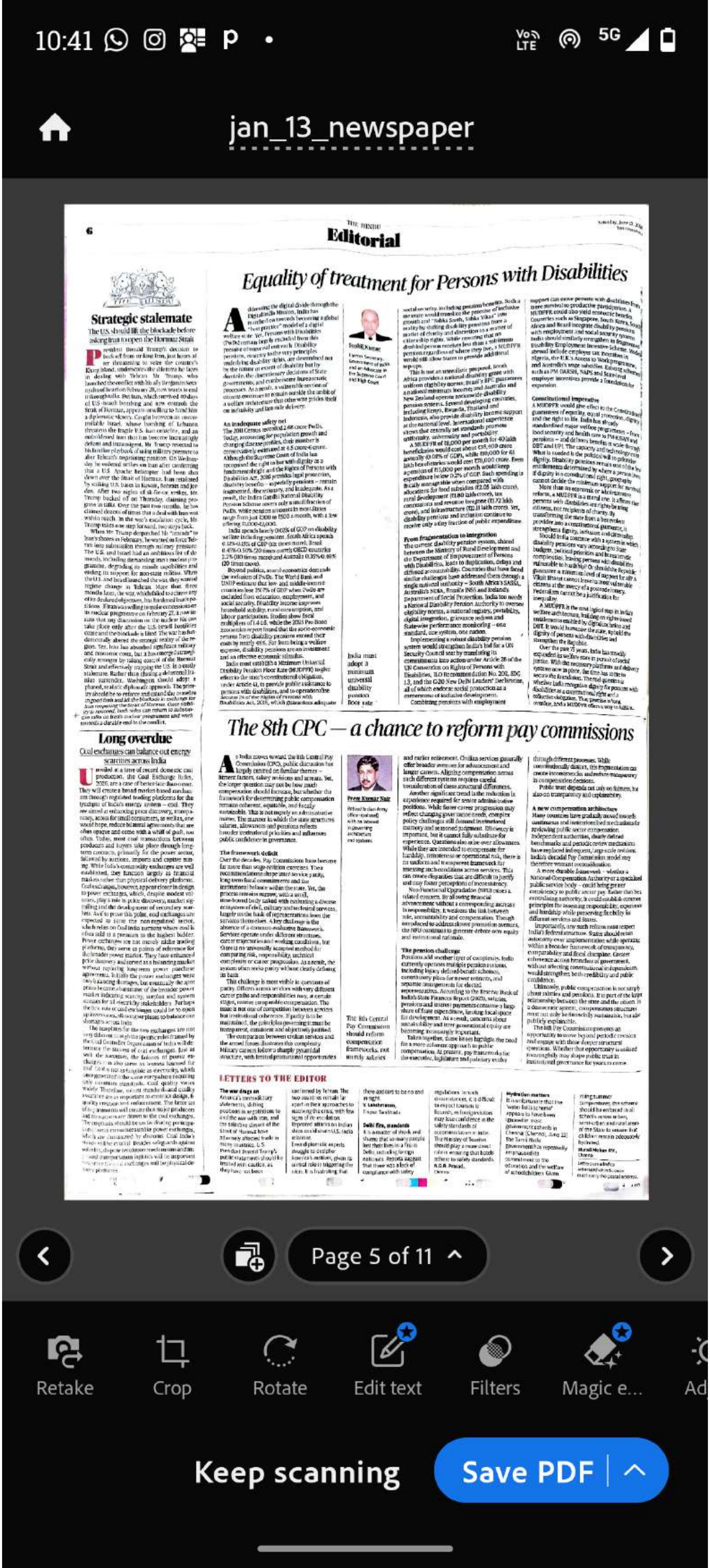
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THE HINDU

Editorial

Strategic stalemate

The U.S. should lift the blockade before asking Iran to open the Hormuz Strait

Long overdue

Coal exchanges can balance out energy scarcities across India

Equality of treatment for Persons with Disabilities

Sushil Kumar

Former Secretary, Government of India and an Advocate in the Supreme Court and High Court

An inadequate safety net

From fragmentation to integration

Constitutional imperative

India must adopt a minimum universal disability pension floor rate

The 8th CPC — a chance to reform pay commissions

Prem Kumar Nair

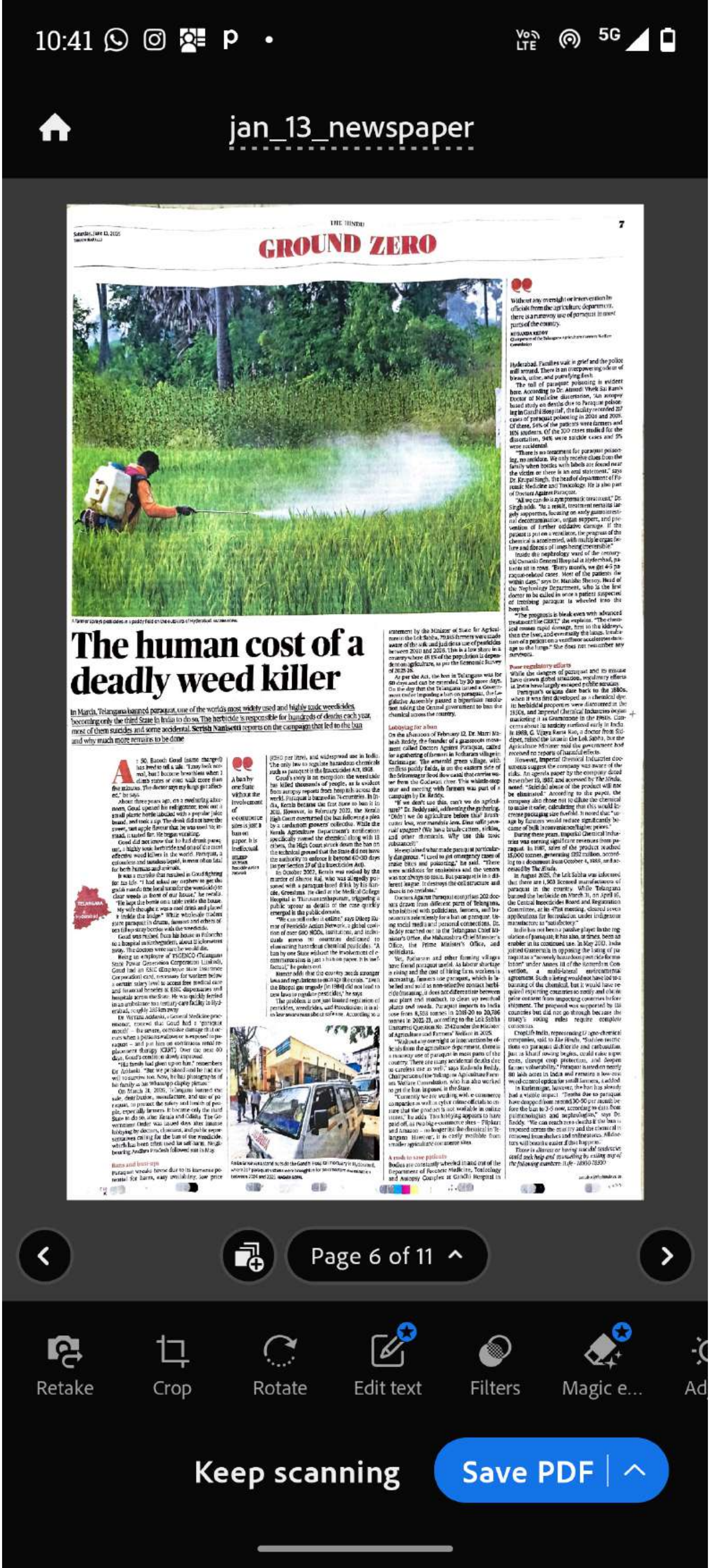
The framework deficit

The pension challenge

A new compensation architecture

The 8th Central Pay Commission should reform compensation frameworks, not merely salaries

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR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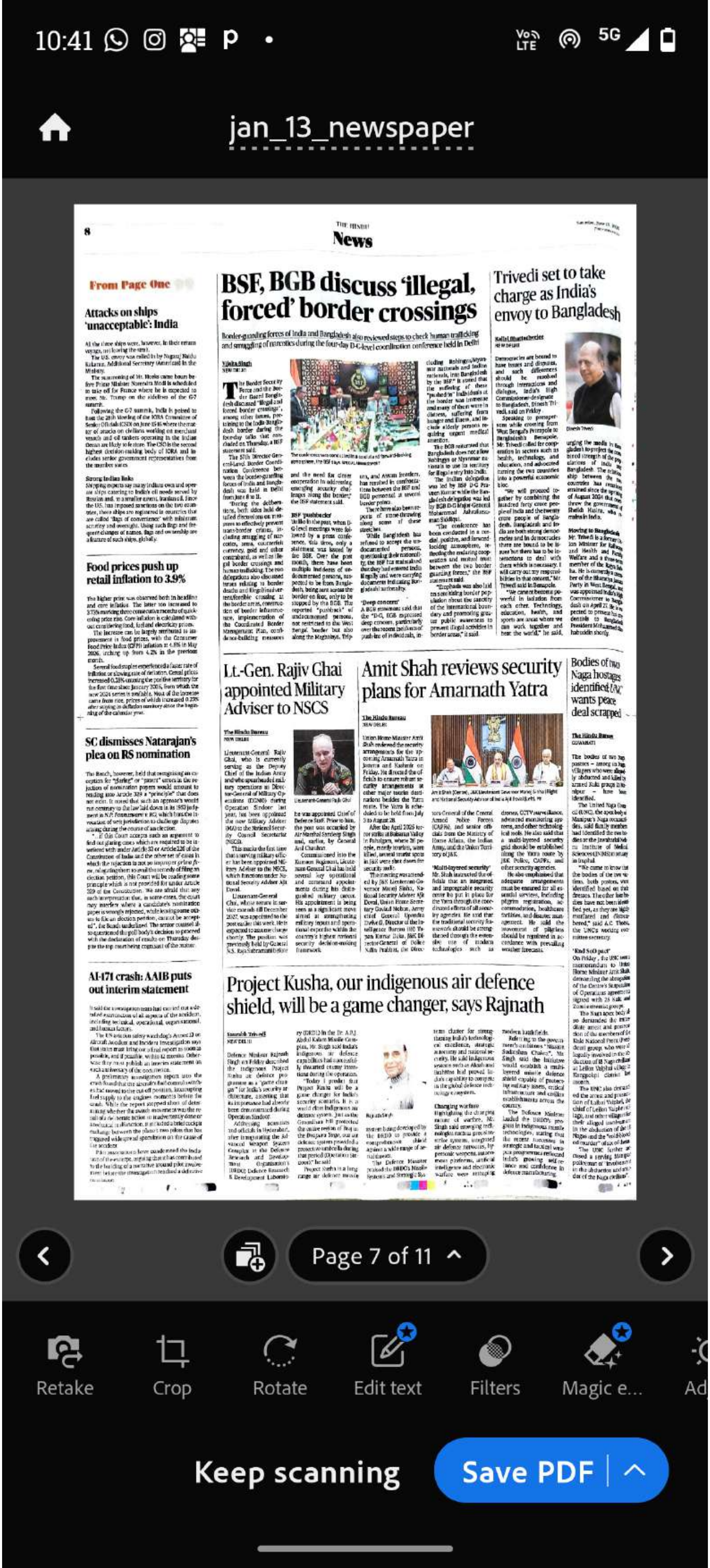
GROUND ZERO

The human cost of a deadly weed killer

In March, Telangana banned paraquat, one of the world's most widely used and highly toxic weedicides, becoming only the third State in India to do so. The herbicide is responsible for hundreds of deaths each year, most of them suicides and some accidental. **Serish Nanisetti** reports on the campaign that led to the ban and why much more remains to be done

> Without any oversight or intervention by officials from the agriculture department, there is a runaway use of paraquat in most parts of the country.

A ban by one State without the involvement of e-commerce sites is just a ban on paper. It is ineffectual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From Page One

Attacks on ships 'unacceptable': India

Food prices push up retail inflation to 3.9%

SC dismisses Natarajan's plea on RS nomination

AI-171 crash: AAIB puts out interim statement

BSF, BGB discuss 'illegal, forced' border crossings

Border-guarding forces of India and Bangladesh also reviewed steps to check human trafficking and smuggling of narcotics during the four-day D-G-level coordination conference held in Delhi

Trivedi set to take charge as India's envoy to Bangladesh

Lt.-Gen. Rajiv Ghai appointed Military Adviser to NSCS

Amit Shah reviews security plans for Amarnath Yatra

Bodies of two Naga hostages identified; UNC wants peace deal scrapped

Project Kusha, our indigenous air defence shield, will be a game changer, says Rajnath

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THE HINDU

News

9

Compromised PM cannot protect sons of India: Rahul

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Country is drifting towards electoral autocracy: Cong.

Congress accuses BJP of subverting democratic institutions for political gain in connivance with the poll body, and says the fight is between the 'constitutional model' and the 'Modi model'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress doesn't require 'neutrality of the Indian state' to function: Rahul

The Congress is a party of resistance... In fact, the more the institutions of the Indian state are throttled, the more aggressively the Congress will fight to defend the Constitution

RAHUL GANDHI
Congress leader

'Resistance works'

4,000 EVMs gutted in Bengal govt. building fire; Minister flags 'foul play'

New govt. will bring Tatas back to Bengal, says Suvendu Adhikari

Jairam urges Defence Minister to reconsider expansion of INS Baaz

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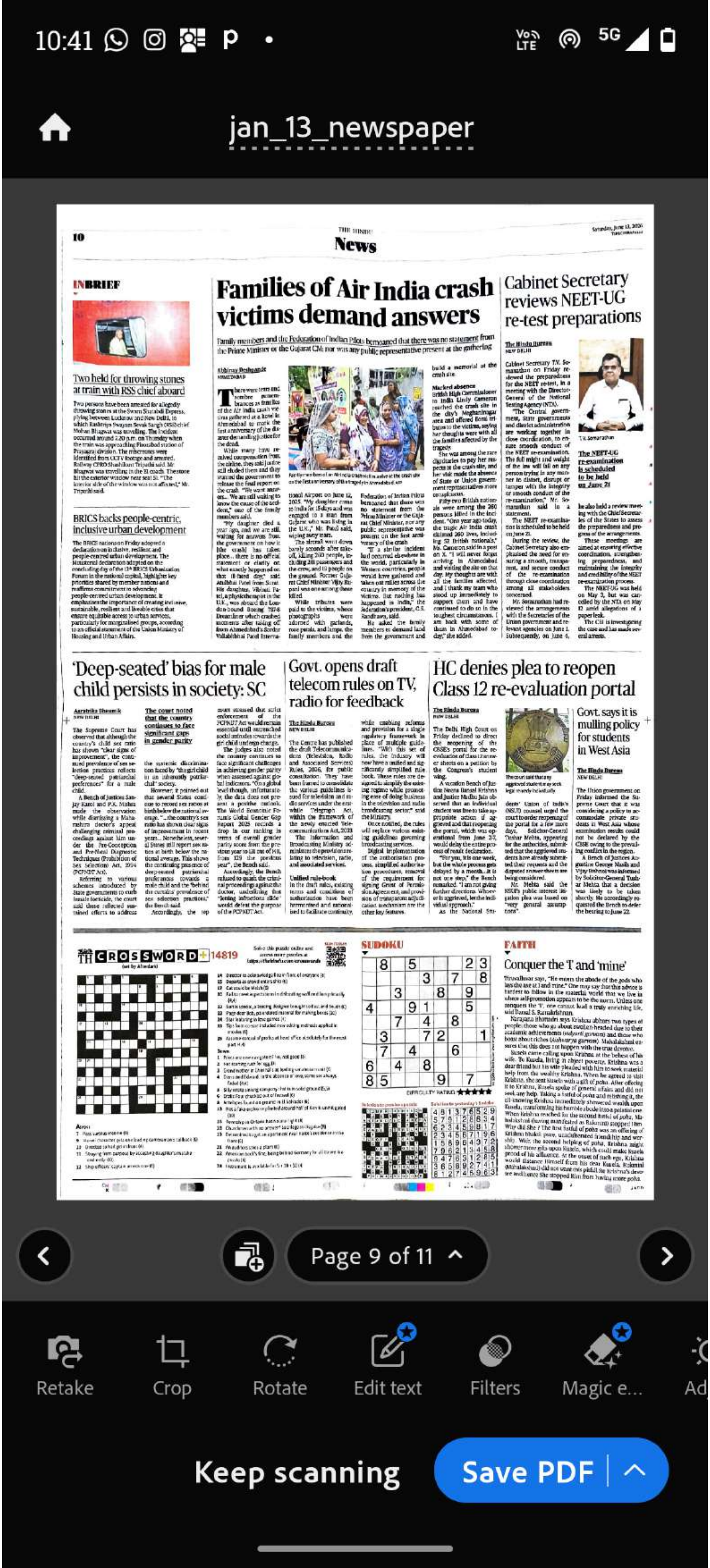

IN BRIEF

Two held for throwing stones at train with RSS chief aboard

Two persons have been arrested for allegedly throwing stones at the Swarn Shatabdi Express, plying between Lucknow and New Delhi, in which Rashtriya Swayam Sevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat was travelling. The incident occurred around 7.20 p.m. on Thursday when the train was approaching Firozabad station of Prayagraj division. The miscreants were identified from CCTV footage and arrested, Railway CPRO Shashikant Tripathi said. Mr. Bhagwat was travelling in the E1 coach. The stone hit the exterior window near seat 51. "The interior side of the window was not affected," Mr. Tripathi said.

BRICS backs people-centric, inclusive urban development

The BRICS nations on Friday adopted a declaration on inclusive, resilient and people-centred urban development. The Ministerial declaration adopted on the concluding day of the 13th BRICS Urbanisation Forum in the national capital, highlights key priorities shared by member nations and reaffirms commitment to advancing people-centred urban development. It emphasises the importance of creating inclusive, sustainable, resilient and liveable cities that ensure equitable access to urban services, particularly for marginalised groups, according to an official statement of the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs.

Families of Air India crash victims demand answers

Family members and the Federation of Indian Pilots bemoaned that there was no statement from the Prime Minister or the Gujarat CM; nor was any public representative present at the gathering

Abhinay Deshpande
AHMEDABAD

There were tears and sombre remembrances as families of the Air India crash victims gathered at a hotel in Ahmedabad to mark the first anniversary of the disaster demanding justice for the dead.

While many have received compensation from the airline, they said justice still eluded them and they wanted the government to release the final report on the crash. "We want answers... We are still waiting to know the cause of the accident," one of the family members said.

"My daughter died a year ago, and we are still waiting for answers from the government on how it [the crash] has taken place... there is no official statement or clarity on what exactly happened on that ill-fated day," said Anilbhai Patel from Surat. His daughter, Vibhuti Patel, a physiotherapist in the U.K., was aboard the London-bound Boeing 787-8 Dreamliner which crashed moments after taking off from Ahmedabad's Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel International Airport on June 12, 2025. "My daughter came to India for 15 days and was engaged to a man from Gujarat who was living in the U.K.," Mr. Patel said, wiping away tears.

The aircraft went down barely seconds after take-off, killing 260 people, including 241 passengers and the crew, and 19 people on the ground. Former Gujarat Chief Minister Vijay Rupani was one among those killed.

While tributes were paid to the victims, whose photographs were adorned with garlands, rose petals, and lamps, the family members and the Federation of Indian Pilots bemoaned that there was no statement from the Prime Minister or the Gujarat Chief Minister, nor any public representative was present on the first anniversary of the crash.

"If a similar incident had occurred elsewhere in the world, particularly in Western countries, people would have gathered and taken out rallies across the country in memory of the victims. But nothing has happened in India," the federation's president, C.S. Randhawa, said.

He asked the family members to demand land from the government and build a memorial at the crash site.

Marked absence

British High Commissioner to India Lindy Cameron reached the crash site in the city's Meghaninagar area and offered floral tributes to the victims, saying her thoughts were with all the families affected by the tragedy.

She was among the rare dignitaries to pay her respects at the crash site, and her visit made the absence of State or Union government representatives more conspicuous.

Fifty-two British nationals were among the 260 persons killed in the incident. "One year ago today, the tragic Air India crash claimed 260 lives, including 52 British nationals," Ms. Cameron said in a post on X. "I will never forget arriving in Ahmedabad and visiting the site on that day. My thoughts are with all the families affected, and I thank my team who stood up immediately to support them and have continued to do so in the toughest circumstances. I am back with some of them in Ahmedabad today," she added.

Family members of an Air India crash victim arrive at the crash site on the first anniversary of the tragedy in Ahmedabad. AFP

Cabinet Secretary reviews NEET-UG re-test preparations

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Cabinet Secretary T.V. Somanathan on Friday reviewed the preparedness for the NEET re-test, in a meeting with the Director-General of the National Testing Agency (NTA).

"The Central government, State governments and district administration are working together in close coordination, to ensure smooth conduct of the NEET re-examination. The full might and weight of the law will fall on any person trying in any manner to distort, disrupt or tamper with the integrity or smooth conduct of the re-examination," Mr. Somanathan said in a statement.

The NEET re-examination is scheduled to be held on June 21.

During the review, the Cabinet Secretary also emphasised the need for ensuring a smooth, transparent, and secure conduct of the re-examination through close coordination among all stakeholders concerned.

Mr. Somanathan had reviewed the arrangements with the Secretaries of the Union government and relevant agencies on June 1. Subsequently, on June 4, he also held a review meeting with the Chief Secretaries of the States to assess the preparedness and progress of the arrangements.

These meetings are aimed at ensuring effective coordination, strengthening preparedness, and maintaining the integrity and credibility of the NEET re-examination process.

The NEET-UG was held on May 3, but was cancelled by the NTA on May 12 amid allegations of a paper leak.

The CBI is investigating the case and has made several arrests.

T.V. Somanathan

The NEET-UG re-examination is scheduled to be held on June 21

'Deep-seated' bias for male child persists in society: SC

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has observed that although the country's child sex ratio has shown "clear signs of improvement", the continued prevalence of sex selection practices reflects "deep-seated patriarchal preferences" for a male child.

A Bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and P.K. Mishra made the observation while dismissing a Maharashtra doctor's appeal challenging criminal proceedings against him under the Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (Prohibition of Sex Selection) Act, 1994 (PCPNDT Act).

Referring to various schemes introduced by State governments to curb female foeticide, the court said these reflected sustained efforts to address the systemic discrimination faced by "the girl child in an inherently patriarchal" society.

The court noted that the country continues to face significant gaps in gender parity

However, it pointed out that several States continue to record sex ratios at birth below the national average. "...the country's sex ratio has shown clear signs of improvement in recent years... Nonetheless, several States still report sex ratios at birth below the national average. This shows the continuing presence of deep-seated patriarchal preferences towards a male child and the 'behind the curtains' prevalence of sex selection practices," the Bench said.

Accordingly, the top court stressed that strict enforcement of the PCPNDT Act would remain essential until entrenched social attitudes towards the girl child undergo change.

The judges also noted the country continues to face significant challenges in achieving gender parity when assessed against global indicators. "On a global level though, unfortunately, the data does not present a positive outlook. The World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Report 2025 records a drop in our ranking in terms of overall gender parity score from the previous year to 131 out of 148, from 129 the previous year", the Bench said.

Accordingly, the Bench refused to quash the criminal proceedings against the doctor, underlining that "letting infractions slide" would defeat the purpose of the PCPNDT Act.

Govt. opens draft telecom rules on TV, radio for feedback

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Centre has published the draft Telecommunications (Television, Radio and Associated Services) Rules, 2026, for public consultation. They have been framed to consolidate the various guidelines issued for television and radio services under the erstwhile Telegraph Act, within the framework of the newly enacted Telecommunications Act, 2023.

The Information and Broadcasting Ministry administers the provisions relating to television, radio, and associated services.

Unified rule-book

In the draft rules, existing terms and conditions of authorisation have been harmonised and rationalised to facilitate continuity, while enabling reforms and provision for a single regulatory framework in place of multiple guidelines. "With this set of rules, the industry will now have a unified and significantly simplified rule book. These rules are designed to simplify the existing regime while promoting ease of doing business in the television and radio broadcasting sector," said the Ministry.

Once notified, the rules will replace various existing guidelines governing broadcasting services.

Digital implementation of the authorisation process, simplified authorisation procedures, removal of the requirement for signing Grant of Permission Agreement, and provision of transparent adjudication mechanism are the other key features.

HC denies plea to reopen Class 12 re-evaluation portal

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Friday declined to direct the reopening of the CBSE's portal for the re-evaluation of Class 12 answer sheets on a petition by the Congress's student wing.

A vacation Bench of Justice Neena Bansal Krishna and Justice Madhu Jain observed that an individual student was free to take appropriate action if aggrieved and that reopening the portal, which was operational from June 2-7, would delay the entire process of result declaration.

"For you, it is one week, but the whole process gets delayed by a month... It is not one step," the Bench remarked. "I am not giving further directions. Whoever is aggrieved, let the individual approach."

As the National Students' Union of India's (NSUI) counsel urged the court to order reopening of the portal for a few more days, Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the authorities, submitted that the aggrieved students have already submitted their requests and the disputed answer sheets are being considered.

Mr. Mehta said the NSUI's public interest litigation plea was based on "very general assumptions".

The court said that any aggrieved student may seek legal remedy individually.

Govt. says it is mulling policy for students in West Asia

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union government on Friday informed the Supreme Court that it was considering a policy to accommodate private students in West Asia whose examination results could not be declared by the CBSE owing to the prevailing conflict in the region.

A Bench of Justices Augustine George Masih and Vijay Bishnoi was informed by Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta that a decision was likely to be taken shortly. He accordingly requested the Bench to defer the hearing to June 22.

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Across

Down

SUDOKU

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution for yesterday's Sudoku

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9	4	7	6	3	1	2	8	5
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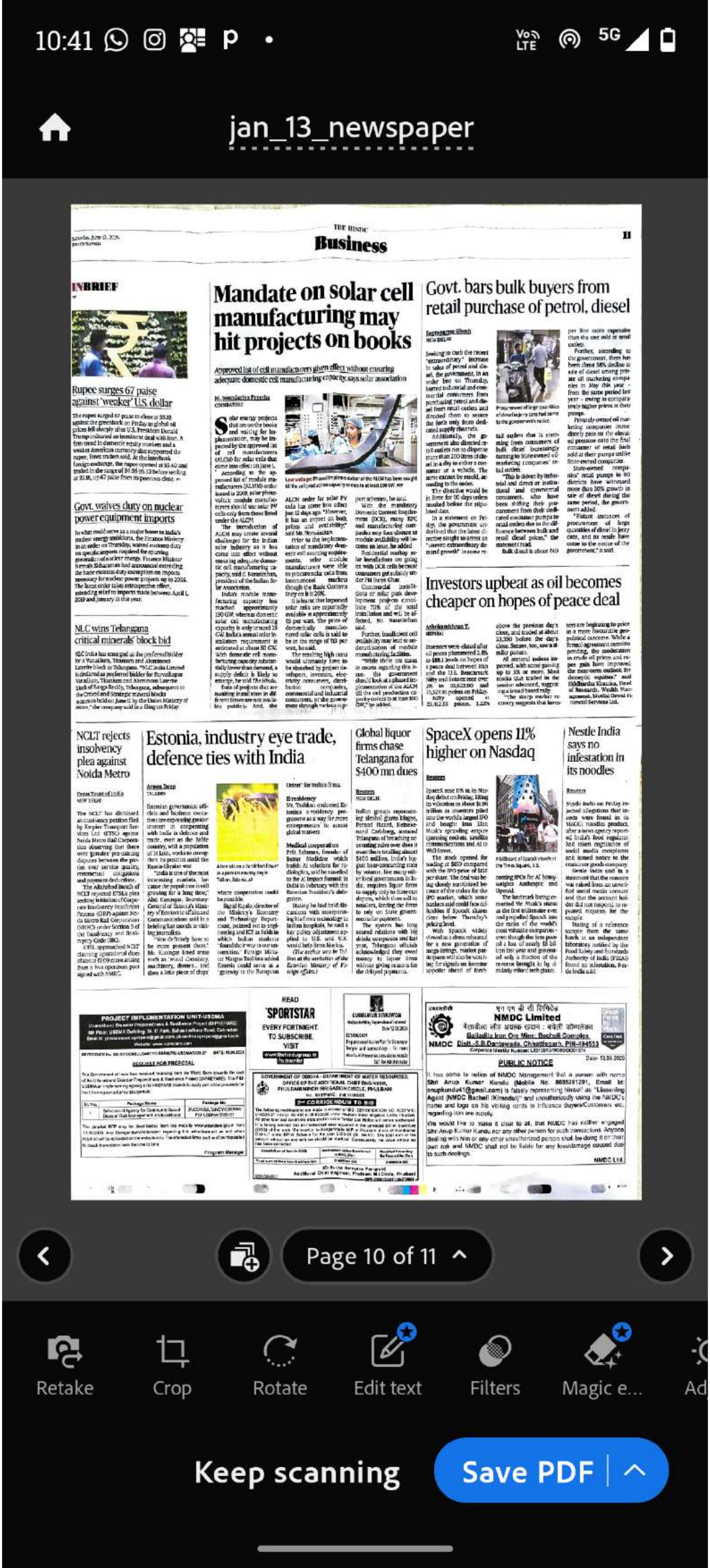
FAITH

Conquer the 'I' and 'mine'

Tiruvalluvar says, "He enters the abode of the gods who lays the axe at I and mine." One may say that this advice is hardest to follow in the material world that we live in where self-promotion appears to be the norm. Unless one conquers the 'I', one cannot lead a truly enriching life, said Damal S. Ramakrishnan.

Narayana Bhattadri says Krishna abhors two types of people: those who go about swollen-headed due to their academic achievements (*vidya garvam*) and those who boast about riches (*aishwarya garvam*). Mahalakshmi ensures that this does not happen with the true devotee.

Kusela came calling upon Krishna at the behest of his wife. To Kusela, living in abject poverty, Krishna was a dear friend but his wife pleaded with him to seek material help from the wealthy Krishna. When he agreed to visit Krishna, she sent Kusela with a gift of *poha*. After offering it to Krishna, Kusela spoke of general affairs and did not seek any help. Taking a fistful of poha and relishing it, the all-knowing Krishna immediately showered wealth upon Kusela, transforming his humble abode into a palatial one. When Krishna reached for the second fistful of *poha*, Mahalakshmi (having manifested as Rukmini) stopped Him. Why did She? The first fistful of poha was an offering of Krishna bhakti: pure, unadulterated friendship and worship. With the second helping of poha, Krishna might shower more gifts upon Kusela, which could make Kusela proud of his affluence. At the onset of such ego, Krishna would distance Himself from his dear Kusela. Rukmini (Mahalakshmi) did not want this pitfall for Krishna's devotee and hence She stopped Him from having more poha.



INBRIEF

Rupee surges 67 paise against 'weaker' U.S. dollar

The rupee surged 67 paise to close at 95.18 against the greenback on Friday as global oil prices fell sharply after U.S. President Donald Trump indicated an imminent deal with Iran. A firm trend in domestic equity markets and a weaker American currency also supported the rupee, forex traders said. At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.40 and traded in the range of 94.95-95.53 before settling at 95.18, up 67 paise from its previous close. PTI

Govt. waives duty on nuclear power equipment imports

In what could serve as a major boost to India's nuclear energy ambitions, the Finance Ministry in an order on Thursday, waived customs duty on specific imports required for generation of nuclear energy. Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman had announced extending the basic customs duty exemption on imports necessary for nuclear power projects up to 2035. The latest order takes retrospective effect, extending relief to imports made between April 1, 2019 and January 31 this year.

NLC wins Telangana critical minerals' block bid

NLC India has emerged as the preferred bidder for a Vanadium, Titanium and Aluminous Laterite block in Telangana. "NLC India Limited is declared as preferred bidder for Burvathapur Vanadium, Titanium and Aluminous Laterite block of Ranga Reddy, Telangana, subsequent to the Critical and Strategic mineral blocks e-auction held on June 11 by the Union Ministry of Mines," the company said in a filing on Friday.

Mandate on solar cell manufacturing may hit projects on books

Approved list of cell manufacturers given effect without ensuring adequate domestic cell manufacturing capacity, says solar association

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE

Solar energy projects that are on the books and waiting for implementation, may be impacted by the approved list of cell manufacturers (ALCM) for solar cells that came into effect on June 1.

According to the approved list of module manufacturers (ALMM) order issued in 2019, solar photovoltaic module manufacturers should use solar PV cells only from those listed under the ALCM.

The introduction of ALCM may create several challenges for the Indian solar industry as it has come into effect without ensuring adequate domestic cell manufacturing capacity, said C. Narasimhan, president of the Indian Solar Association.

India's module manufacturing capacity has reached approximately 190 GW, whereas domestic solar cell manufacturing capacity is only around 25 GW. India's annual solar installation requirement is estimated at about 50 GW. With domestic cell manufacturing capacity substantially lower than demand, a supply deficit is likely to emerge, he told *The Hindu*.

Data of projects that are awaiting installation in different States are not available publicly. And, the ALCM order for solar PV cells has come into effect just 12 days ago. "However, it has an impact on both prices and availability," said Mr. Narasimhan.

Prior to the implementation of mandatory domestic cell sourcing requirements, solar module manufacturers were able to procure solar cells from international markets though the Basic Customs Duty on it is 20%.

It is learnt that imported solar cells are reportedly available at approximately ₹5 per watt. The price of domestically manufactured solar cells is said to be in the range of ₹13 per watt, he said.

The resulting high costs would ultimately have to be absorbed by project developers, investors, electricity consumers, distribution companies, commercial and industrial consumers, or the government through various support schemes, he said.

With the mandatory Domestic Content Requirement (DCR), many EPC and manufacturing companies may face closure as module availability will become an issue, he added.

Residential rooftop solar installations are going on with DCR cells because consumers get subsidy under PM Surya Ghar.

Commercial installations or solar park development projects contribute 70% of the total installation and will be affected, Mr. Narasimhan said.

Further, insufficient cell availability may lead to underutilisation of module manufacturing facilities.

"While there are cases in courts regarding this issue, the government should look at a phased implementation of the ALCM till the cell production capacity comes to at least 100 GW," he added.

Low voltage: Phased implementation of the ALCM has been sought till the cell production capacity comes to at least 100 GW. AFP

Govt. bars bulk buyers from retail purchase of petrol, diesel

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Seeking to curb the recent "extraordinary" increase in sales of petrol and diesel, the government, in an order late on Thursday, barred industrial and commercial consumers from purchasing petrol and diesel from retail outlets and directed them to source the fuels only from dedicated supply channels.

Additionally, the government also directed retail outlets not to dispense more than 200 litres of diesel in a day to either a consumer of a vehicle. The same cannot be resold, according to the order.

The directive would be in force for 90 days unless revoked before the stipulated date.

In a statement on Friday, the government underlined that the latest directive sought to arrest an "uneven extraordinary demand growth" in some retail outlets that is stemming from consumers of bulk diesel increasingly turning to State-owned oil marketing companies' retail outlets.

"This is driven by industrial and direct or institutional and commercial consumers, who have been shifting their procurement from their dedicated consumer pumps to retail outlets due to the difference between bulk and retail diesel prices," the statement read.

Bulk diesel is about ₹40 per litre more expensive than the one sold at retail outlets.

Further, according to the government, there has been about 58% decline in sale of diesel among private oil marketing companies in May this year – from the same period last year – owing to comparatively higher prices at their pumps.

Privately-owned oil marketing companies immediately pass on the elevated pressure onto the final consumer of retail fuels sold at their pumps unlike State-owned companies.

State-owned companies' retail pumps in 80 districts have witnessed more than 30% growth in sale of diesel during the same period, the government added.

"Blatant instances of procurement of large quantities of diesel in jerry cans, and its resale have come to the notice of the government," it said.

Procurement of large quantities of diesel in jerry cans had come to the government's notice.

Investors upbeat as oil becomes cheaper on hopes of peace deal

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Investors were elated after oil prices plummeted 2.8% to $88.1 levels on hopes of a peace deal between Iran and the U.S. Benchmark Nifty and Sensex rose over 2% to 23,622.90 and 75,527.95 points on Friday.

Nifty opened at 23,412.55 points, 1.22% above the previous day's close, and traded at about 23,350 before the day's close. Sensex, too, saw a similar pattern.

All sectoral indices improved, with some gaining up to 3% or more. Most stocks that traded in the session advanced, suggesting a broad-based rally.

"The sharp market recovery suggests that investors are beginning to price in a more favourable geopolitical outcome. While a formal agreement remains pending, the moderation in crude oil prices and rupee gain have improved the near-term outlook for domestic equities," said Siddhartha Khemka, Head of Research, Wealth Management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd.

NCLT rejects insolvency plea against Noida Metro

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The NCLT has dismissed an insolvency petition filed by Empire Transport Services Ltd. (ETSL) against Noida Metro Rail Corporation observing that there were 'genuine' pre-existing disputes between the parties over service quality, contractual obligations and payment deductions.

The Allahabad Bench of NCLT rejected ETSL's plea seeking initiation of Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) against Noida Metro Rail Corporation (NMRC) under Section 9 of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC).

ETSL approached NCLT claiming operational dues of about ₹7.09 crore arising from a bus operations pact signed with NMRC.

Estonia, industry eye trade, defence ties with India

Aroon Deep
TALLINN

Estonian government officials and business executives are expressing greater interest in cooperating with India in defence and trade, even as the Baltic country, with a population of 14 lakh, works to strengthen its position amid the Russia-Ukraine war.

"India is one of the most interesting markets, because the population is still growing for a long time," Ahti Kuningas, Secretary-General of Estonia's Ministry of Economic Affairs and Communications said in a briefing last month to visiting journalists.

"We definitely have to be more present there," Mr. Kuningas listed areas such as 'wood chemistry, machinery, drones... and then a little piece of chips' where cooperation could be possible.

Sigrid Kajalo, director of the Ministry's Economy and Technology Department, pointed out to engineering and ICT as fields in which Indian students "found their way to our universities." Foreign Minister Margus Tsahkna added Estonia could serve as a 'gateway to the European Union' for Indian firms.

E-residency

Mr. Tsahkna endorsed Estonia's e-residency programme as a way for more entrepreneurs to access global markets.

Medical cooperation

Priit Salumaa, founder of Better Medicine which builds AI solutions for radiologists, said he travelled to the AI Impact Summit in Delhi in February with the Estonian President's delegation.

Stating he had held discussions with incorporating his firm's technology in Indian hospitals, he said a key policy adjustment applied to U.S. and U.K. would help firms like his.

(The author was in Tallinn at the invitation of the Estonian Ministry of Foreign Affairs.)

A bee sits on a dandelion flower in a park on a sunny day in Tallinn, Estonia. AP

Global liquor firms chase Telangana for $400 mn dues

Reuters
NEW DELHI

Indian groups representing alcohol giants Diageo, Pernod Ricard, Heineken and Carlsberg, accused Telangana of breaching accounting rules over dues it owes them totalling almost $400 million. India's biggest beer-consuming state by volume, like many other local governments in India, requires liquor firms to supply only to State-run depots, which then sell to retailers, forcing the firms to rely on State governments for payment.

The system has long soured relations with big drinks companies and last year, Telangana officials acknowledged they owed money to liquor firms without giving reasons for the delayed payments.

SpaceX opens 11% higher on Nasdaq

Reuters

SpaceX rose 11% in its Nasdaq debut on Friday, lifting its valuation to about $1.96 trillion as investors piled into the world's largest IPO and bought into Elon Musk's sprawling empire spanning rockets, satellite communications and AI to Wall Street.

The stock opened for trading at $150 compared with the IPO price of $135 per share. The deal was being closely scrutinised because of the stakes for the IPO market, which some bankers said could face difficulties if SpaceX shares close below Thursday's pricing level.

With SpaceX widely viewed as a dress rehearsal for a new generation of mega-listings, market participants will also be watching for signals on investor appetite ahead of forthcoming IPOs for AI heavyweights Anthropic and OpenAI.

The landmark listing cemented Mr. Musk's status as the first trillionaire ever and propelled SpaceX into the ranks of the world's most valuable companies – even though the firm posted a loss of nearly $5 billion last year and generated only a fraction of the revenue brought in by similarly valued tech giants.

A billboard of SpaceX visuals in the Times Square, U.S.

Nestle India says no infestation in its noodles

Reuters

Nestle India on Friday rejected allegations that insects were found in its MAGGI noodles product, after a news agency reported India's food regulator had taken cognisance of social media complaints and issued notice to the consumer goods company.

Nestle India said in a statement that the concern was raised from an unverified social media account and that the account holder did not respond to repeated requests for the sample.

Testing of a reference sample from the same batch at an independent laboratory notified by the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) found no infestation, Nestle India said.

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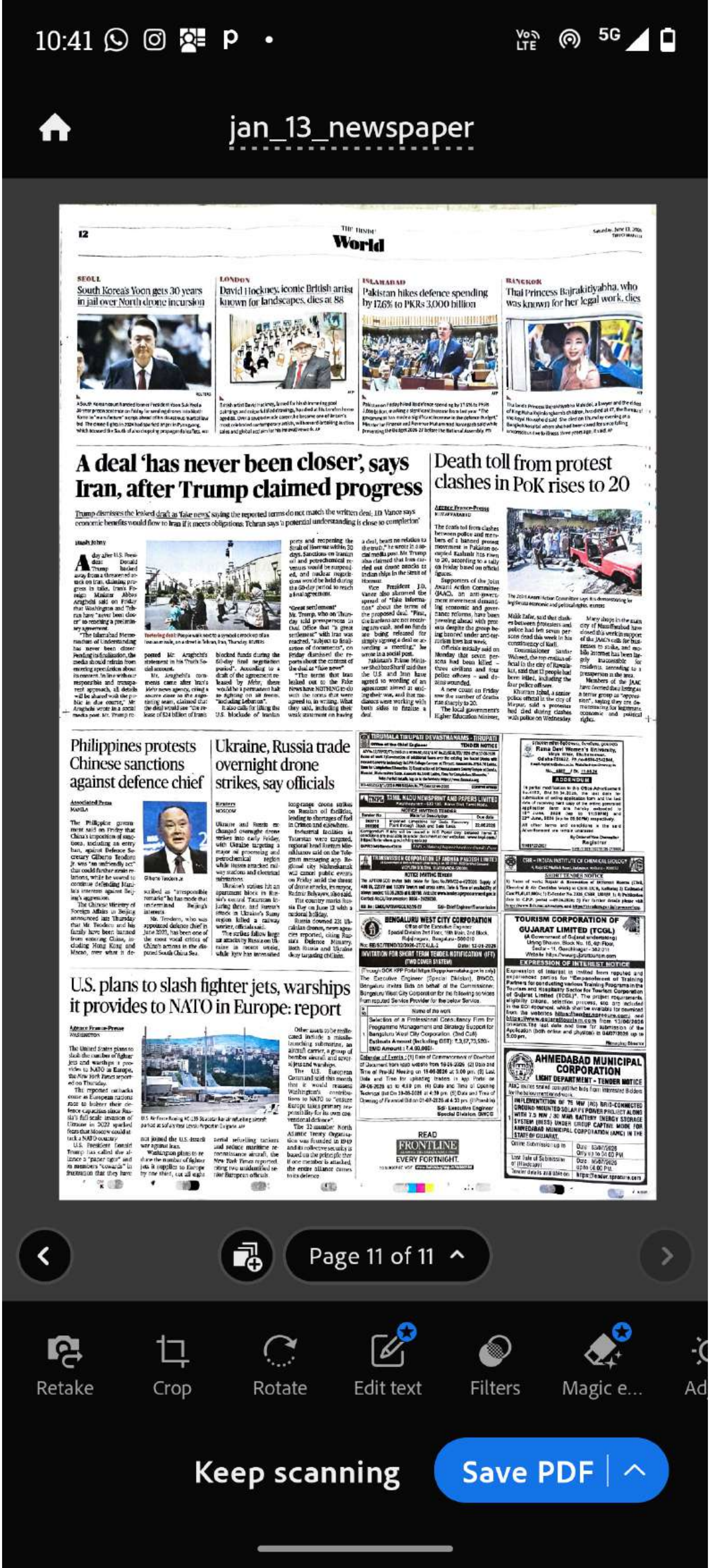
Date- 13.06.2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

It has come to notice of NMDC Management that a person with name Shri Anup Kumar Kundu (Mobile No. 8085281291, Email Id: anupkundu41@gmail.com) is falsely representing himself as "Liasoning Agent (NMDC Bacheli (Kirandul)" and unauthorizedly using the NMDC's name and logo on his visiting cards to influence Buyers/Customers etc. regarding iron ore supply.

We would like to make it clear to all, that NMDC has neither engaged Shri Anup Kumar Kundu nor any other person for such transactions. Anyone dealing with him or any other unauthorized person shall be doing it on their own risk and NMDC shall not be liable for any loss/damage caused due to such dealings.

NMDC Ltd.



SEOUL

South Korea's Yoon gets 30 years in jail over North drone incursion

REUTERS

A South Korean court handed former President Yoon Suk Yeol a 30-year prison sentence on Friday for sending drones into North Korea to "manufacture" a crisis ahead of his disastrous martial law bid. The drone flights in 2024 had sparked anger in Pyongyang, which accused the South of also dropping propaganda leaflets. AFP

LONDON

David Hockney, iconic British artist known for landscapes, dies at 88

AFP

British artist David Hockney, famed for his shimmering pool paintings and colourful iPad drawings, has died at his London home aged 88. Over a seven-decade career, he became one of Britain's most celebrated contemporary artists, with record-breaking auction sales and global acclaim for his inventive works. AP

ISLAMABAD

Pakistan hikes defence spending by 17.6% to PKRs 3,000 billion

AFP

Pakistan on Friday hiked its defence spending by 17.6% to PKRs 3,000 billion, marking a significant increase from last year. "The government has made a significant increase in the defence budget," Minister for Finance and Revenue Muhammad Aurangzeb said while presenting the Budget 2026-27 before the National Assembly. PTI

BANGKOK

Thai Princess Bajrakitiyabha, who was known for her legal work, dies

AFP

Thailand's Princess Bajrakitiyabha Mahidol, a lawyer and the eldest of King Maha Vajiralongkorn's children, has died at 47, the Bureau of the Royal Household said. She died on Thursday evening at a Bangkok hospital where she had been cared for since falling unconscious due to illness three years ago, it said. AP

A deal 'has never been closer', says Iran, after Trump claimed progress

Trump dismisses the leaked draft as 'fake news,' saying the reported terms do not match the written deal; JD Vance says economic benefits would flow to Iran if it meets obligations; Tehran says 'a potential understanding is close to completion'

Stanly Johny

A day after U.S. President Donald Trump backed away from a threatened attack on Iran, claiming progress in talks, Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said on Friday that Washington and Tehran have "never been closer" to reaching a preliminary agreement.

"The Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding has never been closer. Pending its finalization, the media should refrain from entering speculation about its content. In line with our responsible and transparent approach, all details will be shared with the public in due course," Mr. Araghchi wrote in a social media post. Mr. Trump reposted Mr. Araghchi's statement in his Truth Social account.

Mr. Araghchi's comments came after Iran's Mehr news agency, citing a source close to the negotiating team, claimed that the deal would see "the release of $24 billion of Iran's blocked funds during the 60-day final negotiation period". According to a draft of the agreement released by Mehr, there would be a permanent halt to fighting on all fronts, "including Lebanon".

It also calls for lifting the U.S. blockade of Iranian ports and reopening the Strait of Hormuz within 30 days. Sanctions on Iranian oil and petrochemical revenues would be suspended, and nuclear negotiations would be held during the 60-day period to reach a final agreement.

"Great settlement"

Mr. Trump, who on Thursday told presspersons in Oval Office that "a great settlement" with Iran was reached, "subject to finalisation of documents", on Friday dismissed the reports about the content of the deal as "fake news".

"The terms that Iran leaked out to the Fake News have NOTHING to do with the terms that were agreed to, in writing. What they said, including their weak statement on having a deal, bears no relation to the truth," he wrote in a social media post. Mr. Trump also claimed that Iran carried out drone attacks on Indian ships in the Strait of Hormuz.

Vice President J.D. Vance also slammed the spread of "fake information" about the terms of the proposed deal. "First, the Iranians are not receiving any cash, and no funds are being released for simply signing a deal or attending a meeting," he wrote in a social post.

Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said that the U.S. and Iran have agreed to wording of an agreement aimed at ending their war, and that mediators were working with both sides to finalise a deal.

Tottering deal: People walk next to a symbol of a mockup of an Iranian missile, on a street in Tehran, Iran, Thursday. REUTERS

Death toll from protest clashes in PoK rises to 20

Agence France-Presse
MUZAFFARABAD

The death toll from clashes between police and members of a banned protest movement in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir has risen to 20, according to a tally on Friday based on official figures.

Supporters of the Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC), an anti-government movement demanding economic and governance reforms, have been pressing ahead with protests despite the group being banned under anti-terrorism laws last week.

Officials initially said on Monday that seven persons had been killed – three civilians and four police officers – and dozens wounded.

A new count on Friday saw the number of deaths rise sharply to 20.

The local government's Higher Education Minister, Malik Zafar, said that clashes between protesters and police had left seven persons dead this week in his constituency of Kotli.

Commissioner Sardar Waheed, the top civilian official in the city of Rawalakot, said that 12 people had been killed, including the four police officers.

Khurram Iqbal, a senior police official in the city of Mirpur, said a protester had died during clashes with police on Wednesday.

Many shops in the main city of Muzaffarabad have closed this week in support of the JAAC's calls for businesses to strike, and mobile Internet has been largely inaccessible for residents, according to a pressperson in the area.

Members of the JAAC have decried their listing as a terror group as "oppression", saying they are demonstrating for legitimate economic and political rights.

The Joint Awami Action Committee says it is demonstrating for legitimate economic and political rights. REUTERS

Philippines protests Chinese sanctions against defence chief

Associated Press
MANILA

The Philippine government said on Friday that China's imposition of sanctions, including an entry ban, against Defence Secretary Gilberto Teodoro Jr. was "an unfriendly act" that could further strain relations, while he vowed to continue defending Manila's interests against Beijing's aggression.

The Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs in Beijing announced late Thursday that Mr. Teodoro and his family have been banned from entering China, including Hong Kong and Macao, over what it described as "irresponsible remarks" he has made that undermined Beijing's interests.

Mr. Teodoro, who was appointed defence chief in June 2023, has been one of the most vocal critics of China's actions in the disputed South China Sea.

Gilberto Teodoro Jr.

Ukraine, Russia trade overnight drone strikes, say officials

Reuters
MOSCOW

Ukraine and Russia exchanged overnight drone strikes into early Friday, with Ukraine targeting a major oil processing and petrochemical region while Russia attacked railway stations and electrical substations.

Ukraine's strikes hit an apartment block in Russia's central Tatarstan, injuring three, and Russia's attack in Ukraine's Sumy region killed a railway worker, officials said.

The strikes follow large air attacks by Russia on Ukraine in recent weeks, while Kyiv has intensified long-range drone strikes on Russian oil facilities, leading to shortages of fuel in Crimea and elsewhere.

Industrial facilities in Tatarstan were targeted, regional head Rustam Minnikhanov said on the Telegram messaging app. Regional city Nizhnekamsk will cancel public events on Friday amid the threat of drone attacks, its mayor, Radmir Belyayev, also said.

The country marks Russia Day on June 12 with a national holiday.

Russia downed 231 Ukrainian drones, news agencies reported, citing Russia's Defence Ministry. Both Russia and Ukraine deny targeting civilians.

U.S. plans to slash fighter jets, warships it provides to NATO in Europe: report

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

The United States plans to slash the number of fighter jets and warships it provides to NATO in Europe, the *New York Times* reported on Thursday.

The reported cutbacks come as European nations race to bolster their defence capacities since Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022 sparked fears that Moscow could attack a NATO country.

U.S. President Donald Trump has called the alliance a "paper tiger" and its members "cowards" in frustration that they have not joined the U.S.-Israeli war against Iran.

Washington plans to reduce the number of fighter jets it supplies to Europe by one third, cut all eight aerial refuelling tankers and reduce maritime reconnaissance aircraft, the *New York Times* reported, citing two unidentified senior European officials.

Other assets to be reallocated include a missile-launching submarine, an aircraft carrier, a group of bomber aircraft and several jets and warships.

The U.S. European Command said this month that it would reassess Washington's contributions to NATO to "ensure Europe takes primary responsibility for its own conventional defence".

The 32-member North Atlantic Treaty Organisation was founded in 1949 and its collective security is based on the principle that if one member is attacked, the entire alliance comes to its defence.

U.S. Air Force Boeing KC-135 Stratotanker air refueling aircraft parked at Sofia's Vasil Levski Airport in Bulgaria. AFP

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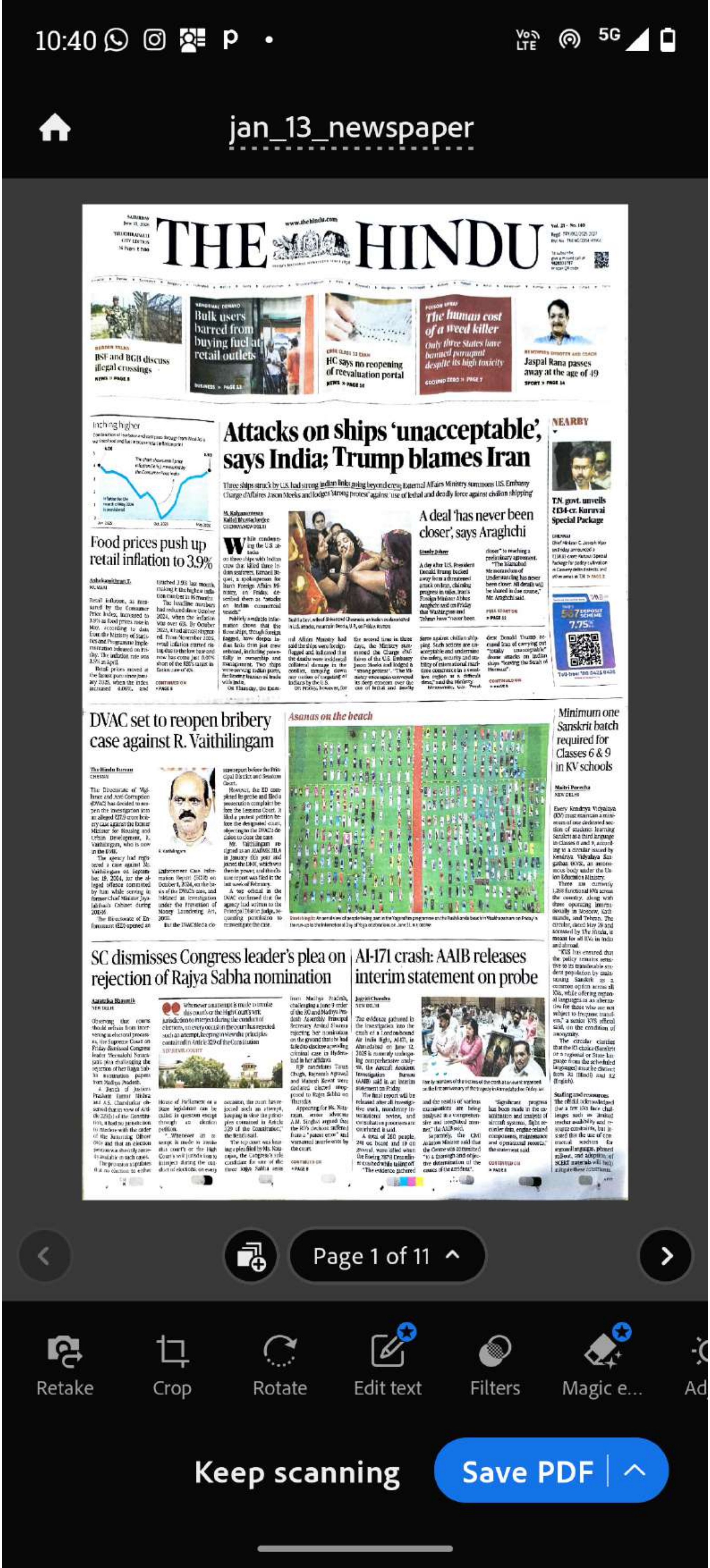

THE HINDU

www.thehindu.com

BSF and BGB discuss illegal crossings

Bulk users barred from buying fuel at retail outlets

HC says no reopening of reevaluation portal

The human cost of a weed killer

Only three States have banned paraquat despite its high toxicity

Jaspal Rana passes away at the age of 49

Inching higher

Food prices push up retail inflation to 3.9%

Attacks on ships 'unacceptable', says India; Trump blames Iran

Three ships struck by U.S. had strong Indian links going beyond crew; External Affairs Ministry summons U.S. Embassy Chargé d'Affaires Jason Meeks and lodges 'strong protest' against 'use of lethal and deadly force against civilian shipping'

A deal 'has never been closer', says Araghchi

NEARBY

T.N. govt. unveils ₹134-cr. Kuruvai Special Package

DVAC set to reopen bribery case against R. Vaithilingam

Asanas on the beach

Minimum one Sanskrit batch required for Classes 6 & 9 in KV schools

SC dismisses Congress leader's plea on rejection of Rajya Sabha nomination

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AI-171 crash: AAIB releases interim statement on probe